Listen and read

Greatest superheroes of all time

1 6.1 Listen to and/or read the article. Which of these superheroes are being described?

Batman The Incredible Hulk Spiderman Superman Wonder Woman Xena, Warrior Princess The X-men

Greatest Superheroes of all time

With their simple stories of good versus evil, comic-book superheroes are as popular today as when they first appeared. So, who are these much-loved characters?

Here is a brief introduction to four of the greatest superheroes of all.

1 _____

In 1939 America, DC Comics seized on the public's desire for escapism during a period of social and economic deprivation, and developed a new superhero. The creators of the 'Man of Steel' wanted a hero in a colourful costume who would look good in a comic book. Although there had been superheroes before, this was the first 'total package' with a costume, secret identity and abilities beyond those of mortal men. Born in a far-off galaxy, the baby hero discovers as he grows up that our sun gives him extraordinary powers: he can fly 'faster than a speeding bullet', has incredible strength and X-ray vision, and can only be hurt or destroyed by a green rock from his original planet, Krypton. He is adopted and brought up by Martha and Jonathan Kent to uphold truth, justice and the 'American way'. Whenever danger calls, he is never far from a telephone box and a quick change, ready to save the world. He's had several TV and film incarnations, the most successful of which starred Christopher Reeve and Margot Kidder in 1978. Ironically, creators Siegel and Shuster signed away their rights to the character for $130!

2 _____

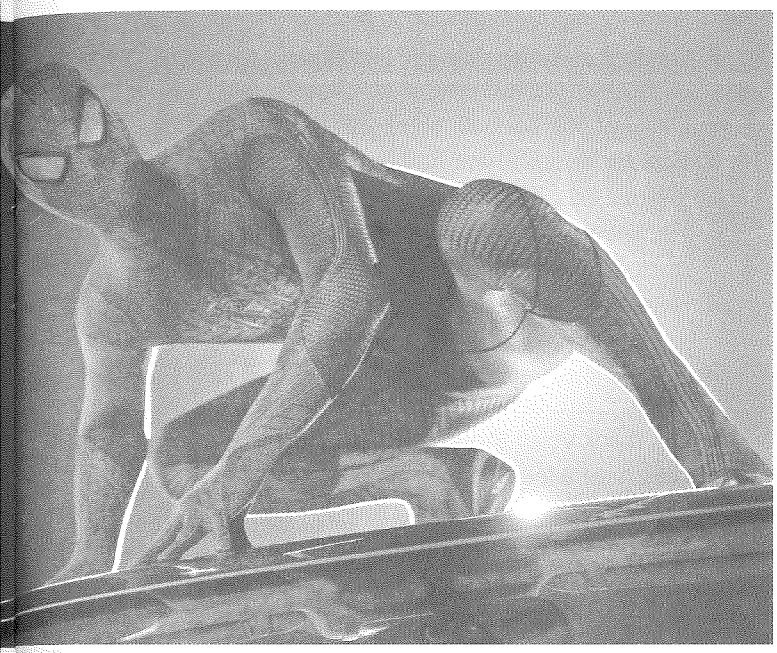
Born on Paradise Island, youthful and immortal, this princess has been blessed by ancient gods and goddesses with powers of super strength and speed and the ability to fly. The superheroine made her first appearance in 1941. It is said she was invented by William Marston for DC Comics as a role model for girls and to raise the morale of US troops in World War II. Her alter-ego, Diana Price, works as a hospital nurse, but transforms herself by flicking her lasso. As well as the lie-detecting lasso, she has bracelets which can stop bullets, but unfortunately she loses her powers if she is tied up with her own lasso. She is instantly recognisable by her stars and stripes costume and in 1976, her adventures were brought to life in a three-year TV series starring ex-Miss USA Beauty Queen, Linda Carter.

3 _____

Created by artist Bob Kane and writer Bill Finger for DC Comics, the stories combined superheroics and a secret identity. This character cannot stop bullets, fly, or look through walls. He is a normal man who becomes one of the greatest crimefighters ever because of his detective skills, highly-trained physical abilities, amazing gadgets, and of course, his 'batmobile' car, kept in a hidden cave beneath his mansion. By day he is rich socialite Bruce Wayne, but at night he turns into 'the caped crusader', accompanied by his side-kick, Robin. He was memorably brought to life in the 1960s TV series and in the film of 1996, starring Michael Keaton, Kim Basinger and Jack Nicholson – a film that featured four of the series' best arch-villains: Catwoman, The Joker, The Penguin and The Riddler.

4 _____

Like many other superheroes, Peter Parker is an orphan, although he has an uncle (Ben) and aunt (Mae). Part of his appeal is that both adolescents and adults can readily identify with him. A poor school student, he goes on to become a regular working guy; a high-school teacher with both girlfriend and money problems. His world is turned upside down when his Uncle Ben is murdered. He gains his superpowers during a high school science demonstration when a radiated spider bites him and gives him superhuman strength and reflexes and the ability to stick to most surfaces. In the movie, which was the biggest money spinner of 2002, Parker grows webslingers which shoot and spin webs, and puts on his red and blue costume to fight arch-enemies such as the Green Goblin and Doctor Octopus.



2 Listen and/or read again and answer the questions.

1 How was Superman different from previous superheroes?

_____

2 Where do his powers come from?

_____

3 What is Superman's only weakness?

_____

4 Who is Martha Kent?

_____

5 Who gave Wonder Woman her powers?

_____

6 Why was Wonder Woman created?

_____

7 What is an 'alter-ego'?

_____

8 What three things can Wonder Woman's lasso do?

_____

9 In what important way is Batman different from the other three superheroes?

_____

10 Who is Batman's alter-ego?

_____

11 Who is his companion in crimefighting?

_____

12 What happened to Peter Parker's parents?

_____

13 Was he born with his superpowers?

_____

14 What two things can he do which give him the name Spiderman?

_____

Language focus 1

Perfect tenses

3 Choose the correct alternative.

1 I can't wait until July! I won't ***have*** / ***have had*** a break since Christmas, so I'll really ***need*** / ***have needed*** a holiday.

2 My New Year's resolutions are to go on a diet and to stop buying so many pairs of shoes! This time next year I'll ***lose*** / ***have lost*** weight and I'll ***have*** / ***have had*** more money to spend.

3 A: Here's the film – will the photos ***be*** / ***have been*** ready by Thursday?
B: Oh, I'm afraid we won't ***do*** / ***have done*** them by then – call in on Friday.

4 A: What's your decision on the takeover deal?
B: Can you give me until tomorrow? By then I'll ***have*** / ***have had*** more time to think about it and I'll ***give*** / ***have given*** you my decision.

5 Maria is doing a two-week lecture tour in Russia. When she gets back she'll ***visit*** / ***have visited*** ten cities and I'm sure she'll ***feel*** / ***have felt*** absolutely exhausted!

4 Use the prompts to write complete sentences, using the Present perfect.

1 I / have / lunch / that restaurant / every day / week.
I've had lunch at that restaurant every day this week.

2 you / finish / homework / yet?

_____

3 I / never / try / Ethiopian food.

_____

4 She / be / that school / January.

_____

5 you / ever / read / any / Bukowski?

_____

6 Many scientists / fear / we / already / pass / the tipping point / for climate change.

_____

7 Good timing! I / just / make / fresh coffee.

_____

8 Tratorie / score / 23 goals / far / season.

_____

9 How long / it / be? I / not see / you / years!

_____

10 What / you / do / today?

_____

5 Complete the text with the Past perfect or Present simple form of the verb in brackets.

Goodbye, CEEFAX!

On 23rd October 2012, TV viewers in the UK [1] *said* [say] goodbye to a national institution: Ceefax, an information service which for nearly forty years [2] _____ [provide] news, weather and even cheap holiday deals on pages which could be read by pressing a special button on your TV remote.

In a special ceremony, Olympic champion Dame Mary Peters [3] _____ it [switch off] at 23:32:19. By the end of 2012, all TVs [4] _____ [move] from an analogue to a digital service, and since Ceefax was also part of the analogue system, it [5] _____ [previously be] decided to switch it off as well.

Ceefax first [6] _____ [go] live in 1974. Researchers at the BBC [7] _____ [develop] it as a way of providing subtitles for deaf viewers, but it soon [8] _____ [become] a popular source of up-to-date information. Before the internet was commonplace, people [9] _____ [use] it to read the most recent and up-to-date news stories.

6 Match a sentence in A with a response in B. Complete each gap with the correct form of *have*.

A

1 Oh dear, I think I *'ve* ___ broken your MP3 player. C
2 You look slimmer than the last time I saw you. ___
3 Shall I phone back at three? ___
4 How long _____ you had your car? ___
5 When _____ finished dinner? ___
6 You were in a bad mood yesterday. ___
7 _____ you seen Mrs Jones this morning? ___
8 Here are your glasses. ___

B

a Yes, I _____ slept well the night before.
b Oh, thank you, I thought I _____ lost them.
c Let's have a look.
d Thanks, I _____ lost six kilos.
e No, she won't be in till this afternoon.
f For about five years, and it's still very reliable.
g Mm, the meeting _____ finished by then. Try at four.
h Probably by about eight-thirty, so you could phone then.

Vocabulary

Human achievements

7 For each sentence below, choose the option which is NOT possible.

1 He spent his lifetime ***discovering*** / (***inventing***) / ***exploring*** new planets.
2 She ***won*** / ***defeated*** / ***led*** the army in the famous battle of 1232.
3 Our campaign has ***raised*** / ***donated*** / ***set*** $50,000 this year. This money will help victims of the recent earthquake.
4 Her work inspired ***others*** / ***speeches*** / ***future generations*** to continue her research.
5 Morovia was ***become*** / ***founded*** / ***led*** by Addicius the Great.
6 The world record was ***set*** / ***written*** / ***broken*** in 2011.
7 The first 3D printers were ***founded*** / ***invented*** / ***developed*** in the 1980s.
8 In 2004, he ***became*** / ***defeated*** / ***gave*** the leader of the opposition.

8a Complete the gaps in the quiz with verbs from the box in the correct form.

~~become~~ discover found give invent
set win write

b Do the quiz.

? QUIZ ?

1 In 1961, who *became* the first man in space?

a Neil Armstrong
b Yuri Gagarin

2 Who ____ the World Wide Web in 1989?

a Bill Gates
b Sir Tim Berners-Lee

3 In 2012, who ____ a new world record for the highest skydive, at approximately 39km?

a Felix Baumgartner
b Usain Bolt

4 Which country ____ the most gold medals at the 2012 Olympics?

a USA
b China

5 Who was one of three people who ____ Apple Inc. in 1976, in order to sell the *Apple I* personal computer kit?

a Bill Gates
b Steve Jobs

6 Who ____ the classic novel *1984*?

a George Orwell
b Ernest Hemingway

7 Who ____ penicillin by mistake, after noticing a fungus growing on one of his/her experiments?

a Marie Curie
b Alexander Fleming

8 Who ____ great speeches on civil rights in the 1950s and 1960s, including a famous one which began, 'I have a dream…'?

a Martin Luther King, Jr.
b Richard Nixon

Writing

A summary

9a A TV company has asked for nominations for 'ordinary heroes' – people from your family or friends who have achieved something incredible. Read this summary and complete the gaps with the phrases in the box.

~~I'd like to nominate~~ As a result of his actions
Eventually He's one of the bravest ... people I know.
In the 1960s It's incredible to think that
it took him years to One

[1] *I'd like to nominate* my grandfather, Charlie, for the programme. [2]_____ and hardest-working _____ .
[3]_____ , before my mother was born, my grandfather and grandmother were living in a poor area of London. My grandfather worked long hours in a factory earning very little, and [4]_____ be able to afford to buy a modest place to live.
[5]_____ night, my grandmother became very ill and needed to go to hospital. Because they couldn't afford a car or any other transport, Charlie carried her all the way to the hospital, some five miles, wrapping her in his coat and rubbing her arms to keep her warm.
[6]_____ they reached the hospital and the doctors said she had arrived just in time, as she had a very low temperature and was close to death. Because Charlie had acted quickly and taken her to the hospital, he had saved her life.
[7]_____ , my grandmother recovered, and later gave birth to my mother.
[8]_____ because of his actions on that cold night, I'm here today to tell the story.

b Write your own nomination for someone in your family or one of your friends. Use the expressions from exercise 9a and think about the following things:

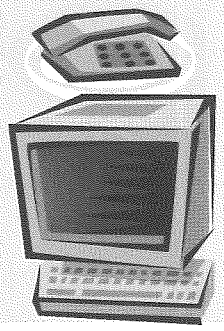
- the background to what they achieved
- what happened
- the effect it (has) had
- why you find it interesting/amazing.

Language focus 2

More about the Present perfect simple and continuous

10 Complete the gaps with the best form of the verb in brackets. Remember to use contractions.

A computer helpline



1 'I *'ve been working* (work) all morning on a document and _____ (only / manage) to print two pages of it.'

2 'I _____ (make) some back-up disks and I think I _____ (lose) one of my files.'

An English student



3 'I'm fed up. This is the third time I _____ (fail) the exam and I _____ (study) here for three years now.'

4 'I _____ (look) for an English–Polish dictionary in the library, but I _____ (only / find) a 1965 edition. The librarian said I should talk to you.'

A radio phone-in programme about health



5 'I feel terrible. I _____ (wake up) at 5 a.m. for the last month. I _____ (try) two different kinds of sleeping pill, but they just make me feel worse.'

6 'My husband _____ (behave) strangely recently. He _____ (start) talking to himself and he _____ (stop) going out with his friends. What do you think's wrong with him?'

11 Tick (✓) the sentences which are correct, and rewrite the sentences which are wrong.

1 Sue's been living with her parents recently. ✓

2 I've been seeing this film before.
I've seen this film before.

3 Since Richard was five, he's been collecting over a million football stickers.

4 Be careful outside. It's snowed.

5 I've been trying to fix this door handle all morning, and still have finished.

6 Well done! You've fixed the problem with my computer!

7 Where have you been? We've waited for nearly an hour!

8 Do you mind if I leave early? I've finished the report you asked me to do.

9 I've always been loving TV dramas.

10 Do you think they're OK? They've been talking in there for ages.

Pronunciation

Weak forms of auxiliary verbs

12a 6.2 **Listen and repeat.**

Have you
/həvjə/
Have you lived
Have you lived here long?
How long
How long have you been
_____ /həvjəbɪn/
How long have you been working here?

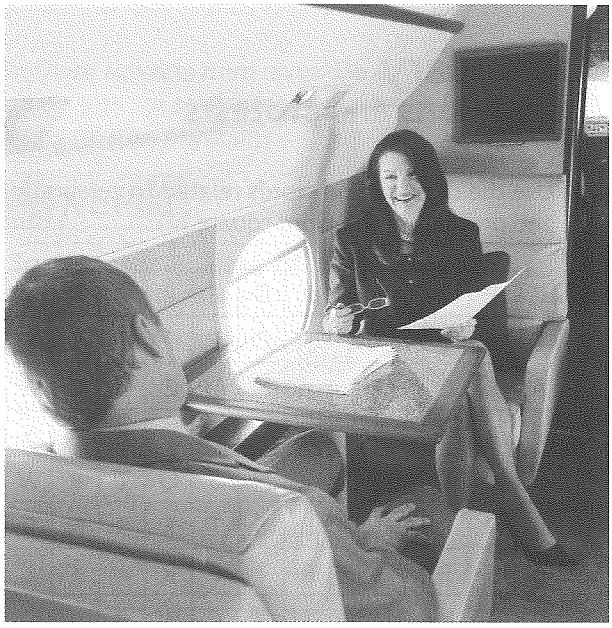
b 6.3 **Listen and write the questions.**

1 *What have you been doing?*
2 _____
3 _____
4 _____
5 _____
6 _____
7 _____
8 _____

c **Listen again and practise saying the questions.**

Wordspot

first



13 **Replace the words in bold with a phrase with *first*.**

1 We travelled in **the best seats**.
first class _____ (2 words)

2 **Initially** I found the job very difficult.
_____ (2 words)

3 They fell in love **when they first saw each other**.
_____ (3 words)

4 Carmen's **mother tongue** is Spanish.
_____ (2 words)

5 I did a course in **giving simple medical help**.
_____ (2 words)

6 **To start with** you need to stand with your skis parallel.
_____ (3 words)

7 You can see Venus **very early** in the morning.
_____ (2 words)

8 I'm afraid your **preferred** holiday dates are not available.
_____ (2 words)

9 When I saw the apartment my **initial opinion** was very positive.
_____ (2 words)

10 '... coming round the bend, Michael Schumacher is **leading**.'
_____ (3 words)